

Who owns your AI – and what happens to you if that changes?

Handbook chapter – Geopolitics and vendor models

1. The question, for this kind of SME

You run a Dutch mechanical engineering or product design firm (20–75 employees) working in SolidWorks, Inventor or Siemens NX. AI is arriving in your design tools and office software. Your question is not "which AI is best?" but: who controls the AI we start depending on, and what happens to our designs, costs and continuity if that changes?

2. The translation

The US, China and the EU each want to own the AI "stack" – chips, computing, models and software – and each says so in official plans.

United States. The US calls AI "a race to achieve global dominance" and wants to export its "full AI technology stack – hardware, models, software, applications, and standards" to allies. Allies are expected to follow US export controls; if not, the US may use "secondary tariffs" (The White House, 2025). For you: most AI tools you use are likely US-owned, so US policy can change their price, availability or terms.

China. China's 15th Five-Year Plan targets breakthroughs in integrated circuits, machine tools, basic and industrial software, and AI chips, building an "independent, controllable" hardware-software ecosystem. Its "AI+" initiative applies AI across the whole industrial life cycle, "including design, pilot testing, production" (People's Republic of China, 2026). For you: Chinese machine builders will compete with AI-supported design, on a separate technology stack.

European Union. The EU puts open-source software at the centre of its technological independence, to reduce lock-in to non-EU vendors (European Commission, 2026). GenAI4EU invests about €700 million in "made in Europe" generative AI for sectors including manufacturing and robotics – yet only 13.5% of EU companies use AI (European Commission, n.d.).

The common thread. All three blocs back open models. Even the US plan says open-weight models let businesses avoid "being dependent on a closed model provider" and keep sensitive data in-house (The White House, 2025). That is your main lever.

3. Illustrative use case (CRISP-DM) – fictional firm

A 40-person machine builder wants AI to speed up concept design. Business: cut concept time without losing control of customer designs. Data: years of CAD files, some under NDA. Preparation: classify files as public, internal or confidential. Modelling: test a closed cloud AI tool against an open model running on a local workstation. Evaluation: compare time saved, quality, where data goes, and what happens if the vendor changes price or terms. Deployment: cloud AI for non-sensitive work, open local model for NDA projects.

4. Recommended tooling

(a) Closed cloud AI inside your current software – low effort, subscription, highest dependency on its owner. (b) European generative AI solutions supported by GenAI4EU – low–medium effort, EU-based (European Commission, n.d.). (c) Open-source/open-weight model on your own PC – medium effort, one-off hardware, data stays in-house (European Commission, 2026; The White House, 2025).

5. Responsible AI & trust

Know who owns each tool and where your files go; never upload NDA designs unchecked. Treat AI designs as proposals that a qualified engineer approves. Keep a manual fallback for every AI step, and train staff rather than replace their judgement.

6. First five steps for an owner

1. List every AI tool you use: owner, home country (US, China, EU) and where data is stored.
2. Classify your files and decide what never goes into a closed cloud AI.
3. Check contracts for data use, price changes and exit terms.
4. Define a plan B per tool: a European or open-source option, or a manual process.
5. Look for GenAI4EU pilots or calls for manufacturing firms to test a European option.

References

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